

The Cardinal’s Promise

Nineteen-reader panel — findings, fixes, and open decisions

PREPARED FOR ROB BRIZZI · AUGUST 2026 · MANUSCRIPT AT 58,000 WORDS

Nineteen simulated reviewers read the complete manuscript, each through one lens — the people who would sell the book, the specialists who would edit it, and the readers who actually live these pages. Every reviewer returned a score, strengths and problems pinned to specific chapters, and the single change they would demand. Nobody scored it below 5.5. Nobody called it finished.

6.74	5.5–7.5	19
AVERAGE SCORE	FULL RANGE	REVIEWERS

The spread tells its own story. **The people who would sell the book scored it lowest** — literary agent and Big Five editor both 5.5, on platform and structure, not prose. **The people the book is for scored it highest** — the recovery reader, sensitivity reader, Christian reader, craft teacher, and audiobook producer all landed at 7.5.

SCORE	LENS
7.5	Recovery reader · Sensitivity reader · Christian reader · Memoir craft teacher · Audiobook producer
7.4	Secular reader
7.0	Hospice nurse · Bereaved reader
6.8	Adult adoptee
6.5	Trade critic · Cold reader · Structure editor · Continuity checker · Bookseller · Mother of an addict
6.4	Line editor
6.0	Mexican-American reader
5.5	Literary agent · Acquiring editor

01 What every reviewer praised

Four things drew unprompted praise across lenses, several called best-in-genre:

- **The Prologue.** The Tijuana holding cell, and the four words that end it — *“I came back the next day.”* The craft teacher would *teach* it.
- **Chapter 15, West Palm Beach.** Post-it walls, the extension cord stealing power from the hallway, Lou asleep on the carpet, the bagel waiting in the morning — and the refusal of the redemption beat: *the rescue didn’t get me sober, it kept me alive long enough to get there.* The agent said that refusal is what separates this from a thousand addiction memoirs.

- **Chapter 20, Horacio.** “*One father kept calling. The other one kept coming.*” Named as the book in one sentence.
- **Lou himself**, built out of ordinary acts rather than claims — Tootsie Rolls, adoption paperwork, the drives.

02 Consensus problems, by how many reviewers found them independently

REVIEWERS FINDING

10 of 19	The book ends five times. The cardinal epilogue is a true ending; six back-matter sections then keep going, and <i>Tyler and Jaye</i> introduces a new devastating story in the reader’s exit path.
8 of 19	The middle sags. Chapter 19’s five sequential mentor portraits and Chapter 26’s catalogs. The cold reader nearly stopped at Chapter 19.
6 of 19	“Showing up” appears 62 times. A thesis-word that becomes wallpaper; audio amplifies what print conceals.
5 of 19	Chapter 28’s title is the wrong door into “The Last Chapter” — the reader arrives braced for the father’s death and meets an Ozempic punchline.
4 of 19	Genuine continuity contradictions , two of them under load-bearing scenes.
3 of 19	Category straddle. Scripture on all 33 chapters plus the Tijuana cell and the strip-club confession — each shelf flinches at the other half.

03 Fixed since the panel

DONE **The safety line in Chapter 15.** The sensitivity reader would not sign off on “*without even the courage to do anything about it*” — it frames dying as courage and surviving as failing to manage it. Rewritten to keep the powerlessness and drop the valor. cc5021a

DONE **“Show up” thinned from 62 uses to 41.** Eighteen of the weakest instances now name the concrete thing they stood for. Untouched: the dedication, the creed, “*I showed up, and when it got hard I showed up harder,*” and the last line of the book. 0f1d57a

DONE **Lou’s age reconciled.** Chapter 3 said he was forty-one in 1984; the dedication (1941–2025) and both illness chapters say otherwise. Now forty-three — and Chapter 33’s “*Lou spent eighty-four years*” independently confirms 1941. His own quoted “ten years younger” stays as spoken: a man bragging in a bar, rounding. a8551ea

DONE **The first-pill contradiction resolved.** Chapters 10 and 13 each staged the same revelation as *the first time*, six years apart — the causal keystone of the book quietly accusing itself of fiction. Confirmed by the author: Oxford, with Justin, 1999. Chapter 10 now carries the year; Chapter 13 becomes escalation rather than discovery — “*I already knew the feeling... What was different in San Diego was that I stopped waiting for it to find me... Not discovering it. Deciding to live there.*”

DONE **Two datelines corrected to match their scenes.** Chapter 33 was stamped 2025 but opens days after the January 2026 funeral. Chapter 26 was stamped 2018 but runs through the East Hill sale in 2026. cc5021a

DONE **Chapter 28 retitled “The Detour.”** The joke existed only in the heading — nothing in the chapter earned it — so retitling cost nothing and removed both the tonal problem (a punchline at the door of the father’s death) and the exposure of joking about a named employer’s product.

DONE **The book now ends once.** The divider already told the reader “*the story ends with the cardinal.*” What remained was the closing piece restating the thesis a third time and finishing on a command. Two imperatives already said by the Epilogue and *Lou’s Way* are cut, and the final line stops ordering the reader: “*That is the cardinal’s promise. It was done for me.*” The section now ends on Lou — “*He stayed.*”

04 Open — needs your decision

STRATEGIC **Two notes you can’t edit your way out of.** The agent and acquiring editor both said the sellable hook — *a hospice liaison whose father starts dying five weeks into the job* — is buried 250 pages deep, and would restructure the book around it. Separately, three reviewers said Part Six reads like grief transcribed from inside the fog. Both are strategy calls, and both are yours alone.

All nineteen reviews are retained in full with citations to specific chapters and passages. Manuscript current at 205 pages (KDP interior); cover-wrap spine requires recalculation from the locked 226-page figure before upload.